Fort Dearborn

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

One August morning in 1812, on the ground that is now downtown Chicago, ninety-odd people marched out of a fort — and walked into an event the city has spent two hundred years arguing how to name.

This was Native ground first

For roughly two centuries before there was a Chicago, the low, marshy portage where the Chicago River nearly touches the Illinois watershed was Potawatomi country — part of the homeland of the Three Fires, the allied Potawatomi, Ojibwe, and Ottawa nations, whose territory ran from Green Bay to Detroit. The portage was a hinge of a continent: whoever held it touched the fur trade of half the Great Lakes.

In 1795, after the Northwest Indian War, the Treaty of Greenville pried loose a first foothold — a six-square-mile tract at the mouth of the river, ceded to the United States. It was a small square on a map. It was also the opening wedge of a much larger taking, and everyone at the time understood it that way.

A Native encampment beside the Chicago River — oil lunette, early 20th century. Public domain.

A confederacy, and a choice of sides

By 1810 a pan-tribal resistance had formed around the Shawnee brothers Tecumseh and Tenskwatawa ("the Prophet"), who called on Native nations to stop ceding land and to push the Americans back. When the United States and Britain went to war in June 1812, many Great Lakes tribes allied with the British — not out of loyalty to a king, but, as a Chicago marker would finally put it in 2009, "to stop the westward expansion of the United States and to regain lost Indian lands."

These were the leaders and nations whose land the fort sat on — not a backdrop to the American story, but people making hard calculations in a war closing in around them.

Me-Te-A, a Potawatomi chief — hand-colored lithograph, McKenney & Hall, c. 1836, public domain.

A fort at the mouth of the river

In 1803 a small company of U.S. soldiers under Captain John Whistler built a log stockade on the south bank of the river and named it Fort Dearborn, for Secretary of War Henry Dearborn. Around it grew the beginnings of a settlement — the trader John Kinzie's house across the water, an agency, a few cabins. One officer called it "so remote from the civilized part of the world."

It was never a mighty fortress. It was a lonely government outpost on someone else's land, dependent on supply lines that a war could cut in a week.

"Old Fort Dearborn, erected at the mouth of Chicago River" — Kellogg lithograph, public domain.

The fort in its own hand

We do not have to imagine the fort. Its own builders drew it. This is the plan of Fort Dearborn — two blockhouses at opposite corners, a powder magazine, soldiers' and officers' quarters, a guard house and hospital, a contractor's store, and a 75-foot flagstaff in the parade, all ringed by a double log stockade with a main gate and a small gate to the river.

A drawing like this is a primary source: made at the time, for a real purpose (to report to Washington what stood there). Notice what it tells you plainly — and what it leaves out, like who lived on the land around it.

Plan of Fort Dearborn — two blockhouses, the magazine, barracks, and a 75-foot flagstaff inside a double stockade. Line drawing after the original, public domain.

The people inside

By 1812 the fort was commanded by Captain Nathan Heald, who had taken over from Whistler and married Rebekah Wells the year before. The garrison was small — a few dozen regulars and militia, with nine women and eighteen children among the families.

Rebekah's uncle was William Wells — a white man captured as a boy and raised among the Miami, who had lived on both sides of the frontier and now served the United States. When word came that the fort was in danger, Wells rode from Fort Wayne with a party of Miami to help. Among the Potawatomi nearby was Black Partridge, who had U.S. friendships he was about to find himself unable to protect.

Capt. Nathan Heald, commander of Fort Dearborn — miniature portrait, public domain.

The order to abandon the fort

The war went badly fast. The British took Fort Mackinac to the north on July 17, and General William Hull, fearing Fort Dearborn could not be held or supplied, ordered it evacuated. Heald was to give the fort's goods to the local Native people to smooth the retreat — but he then destroyed the extra guns, ammunition, and whiskey rather than hand them over, a decision many believe enraged the very people whose escort he needed.

On the night of August 14, Black Partridge came to Heald, returned a peace medal the Americans had given him, and warned that he could no longer restrain the young men. The next morning the column formed up anyway and marched out along the lakeshore trail, south.

"Chicago in 1812" — the fort, the Indian trail running south along the lake, and the 'Battle Ground of 1812.' Map, public domain.

Fifteen minutes

About a mile and a half south of the fort, near today's Roosevelt Road, some 500 Potawatomi attacked the column. The fighting was brief — roughly fifteen minutes. When it ended, most of the evacuees were dead or captured: by Heald's own report, 26 regulars, all 12 militia, 2 women, and 12 children were killed; the Potawatomi lost about 15 men. William Wells was killed defending the wagons of women and children.

The lopsided toll — and the deaths of women and children — is why the event was called a massacre for a century and a half. The context — a war, a fort on ceded land, a people defending it — is why many now call it a battle. Hold on to both facts; you will weigh them at the end.

The Fort Dearborn fight, August 15, 1812 — a 19th-century wood engraving (Hooper). Public domain. Note how the engraver stages the scene — whose fear is at the center, and whose faces are made monstrous.

The fort in ashes

The survivors surrendered and were taken as captives to Potawatomi villages; the next day the fort was burned. Some prisoners died in captivity; others were ransomed and traded over the following months. For a time, the site emptied of U.S. citizens entirely — the American presence at Chicago simply ended.

It did not end for long. The fort was rebuilt in 1816, and the settlement began again on the same ground — this time to keep growing.

"Burning of Old Fort Dearborn, 1812" — color postcard, public domain.

What a "victory" cost

For the Potawatomi it was a clear military victory. But it hardened an American conviction that would prove catastrophic for Native people: that the tribes could never be neighbors and must be removed. Within a generation that logic was law.

In the 1833 Treaty of Chicago, the Potawatomi ceded their remaining lands around the city; by 1835 most were forced west of the Mississippi — marked, one account says, by the last great gathering of the tribes on the ground that was becoming Chicago. The city rose on the exact place its first inhabitants were made to leave.

"Map of Chicago in 1830," Andreas — still marking the 'Site of Massacre of 1812' and 'Site of Surrender.' Public domain.

The monument that came down

In 1893 the industrialist George Pullman paid for a bronze monument by sculptor Carl Rohl-Smith. It froze one dramatic instant: the Potawatomi Black Partridge shielding a white woman, Margaret Helm, from another warrior's tomahawk. For decades it stood as Chicago's official memory of 1812 — a rescue, starring a "good Indian," framed for the people who commissioned it.

Native American groups objected to that framing for just as long. The statue was removed in the 1970s; efforts to reinstall it have met continued resistance, and it remains in storage and in dispute. A monument, it turns out, is an argument — and arguments can be taken down.

The Fort Dearborn Massacre Monument — Carl Rohl-Smith, 1893: Black Partridge staying the tomahawk to save Margaret Helm. Photograph, public domain.

A century of restagings

Every generation retold it in its own key. For years Chicagoans made pilgrimages to a giant cottonwood said to mark the spot — though a later historian showed the tree wasn't old enough to have been there in 1812. The story wanted a shrine, so it found one.

In 1933, at the “Century of Progress” world’s fair, the city built a full-scale replica of the fort and staged anniversary pageants inside it. The word on the banner was still massacre. Notice the pattern: each retelling says as much about the people telling it as about 1812.

The ‘Massacre Tree,’ a cottonwood long said to mark the site — wood engraving, 1884. Public domain.

The city changes its mind

Today the fort itself is gone — only bronze lines in the pavement mark where it stood. But two other markers near the river tell the story in flatly opposite ways. One was carved in 1928, into the great bridge relief called Defense. The other was set in the ground in 2009. They describe the same fifteen minutes.

That is your job now. Scroll down, read what each one actually says, and decide: whose story is this — a massacre, or a battle?

“Site of Fort Dearborn” — a bronze marker set in the sidewalk near Michigan Avenue and Wacker Drive. Photograph, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).